sailors or lascars landed on American soil. Some of the lascars settled in New York City's Harlem and other cities, starting families with women of different nationalities and races.[34] A more systematic migration stream developed in the early 20th century when the Punjabi Sikhs, serving in the British Indian army in East Asia, began to migrate to the west coast of America in the early 20th century, to work on the railway lines and lumber in the north and agriculture in the south. This was the migration that led to the growth of successful peach grower Didar Singh Bains in California, as noted in the previous chapter.

Student migration began in the late 19th century and attracted Anandibai Joshee, the first known Indian woman to receive an educational degree in the US, as early as in the 1880s. Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT) on the East Coast grew in prominence as a destination for science and engineering students from India, while Stanford and other universities on the west coast also began admitting Indian students. Even then, the total number of India-born immigrants in the US was less than 5000 in 1920.

The appearance of Indians as students and workers, all labelled Hindus irrespective of religion, was not well appreciated in early 20th century America. The mass migration of Europeans to America between 1850 and 1914 had acted as an important safety valve for their populations, but when other regions began aspiring to the American dream, there was a racial backlash and steep visa walls were erected to block Asians. According to an official report in 1910, Indians were 'the most undesirable of all Asiatics and the peoples of the Pacific states were unanimous in their desire for exclusion'.[35] In such a milieu, for five decades, immigration laws discriminated against most nationalities.

Amidst the civil rights movement and Cold War politics, these visa walls were torn down by the landmark Immigration and Nationality Act of 1965, opening the doors for millions around the world. But unlike in the past, the new immigration laws were biased towards skilled migrants. This did not matter much for neighbouring countries like Mexico as labour migrants could still slip in as undocumented workers, but for distant shores like